Meanwhile, Mackenzie and Lawrence were being abducted. Both men were ‘surrounded by a circle of Ghilzai with drawn swords and cocked jezails, and the cries of “Kill the Kafir” became more vehement?. . .’ But Akbar Khan protected them. He drew his sword ‘and laid about himself right manfully’, as Mackenzie gratefully noted. ‘Pride, however, overcame his sense of courtesy when he thought I was safe; for he then turned around to me, and repeatedly said, in a tone of triumphant derision: “*Shuma mulk-i-ma me-girid!* – You’ll seize my country will you?”’[125] At the same time, Lawrence was also being bundled away at gunpoint through crowds of angry Ghilzais all crying for a ‘Koorban’ [sacrifice] to the Ghilzai headquarters at the fort of Mahmud Khan, where the two captives were shoved into a cell. Just before the door closed, one tribesman took a swipe with his sword at Mackenzie. Mohammad Shah Khan Ghilzai, who was standing close by, put his arm around Mackenzie to protect him, and took the cut on his own shoulder.[126]

Shortly afterwards, Aminullah Khan Logari, the supposed victim of Macnaghten’s plot, burst in on the two prisoners and told them that they were soon to be blown from the mouths of cannon. Outside their cell, Ghilzais gathered to taunt the two captive Kafirs. They spat, poked their swords and guns through the bars, and tried to break down the door of the cell. The guards only just managed to stop the crowd murdering the prisoners. A few minutes later there was another commotion and the prisoners looked out to see a human hand impaled on a pole. ‘Look well!’ screamed the Ghilzais; ‘your own will soon suffer a similar plight.’

It was the hand of the Envoy. Macnaghten’s and Trevor’s heads were then paraded on the tips of spears, while their trunks were dragged through the streets, then skinned, and their hides hung from a meat hook in the bazaar.[127] Even Macnaghten’s large blue spectacles were put on display.[128] ‘All came to see the remains exposed there,’ remarks Mirza ‘Ata,

> and to spit in disgust. The gold coin of honesty and scrupulous respect for one’s engagements is a currency valid everywhere, which will preserve its owner from dishonour even in the most turbulent circumstances. ‘If you are faithful and true, people will love you; deceit will only make people shun and loathe you!’ As it was, Sardar Muhammad Akbar Khan’s fame spread, and everyone repeated how all the English achieved was to drive the famished donkeys of their failed ambition back into India and to force the women of India to wear the weeds of widowhood in mourning for their husbands! It was clear to all that those Englishmen who had